

INK MORROW 5.0 DEVELOPMENT EDITION

User Guide

Follow the cast, steer the story, return to a living world

For readers and directors of the 5.0 development edition / September 2026

InkMorrow 5.0 — User Guide

Development edition. This guide describes the reader-director interface on the 5.0 release branch. Illustrated stories, playable saves and book export are included. The final fresh-storage/version cutover is still in development.

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01 A story worth following

InkMorrow is playable fiction. You normally remain outside the cast: you follow their lives, decide what deserves attention, and influence what unfolds. You do not need an avatar, a character sheet, or a main character representing you. Reading and inviting the story to continue are valid ways to play.

You can also choose to inhabit a character. That is an explicit, reversible handoff, not a requirement or an automatic consequence of starting a story. The same story, history, facts and paths continue whichever way you participate.

The story text is the experience itself. It does not need a later conversion from a roleplay transcript into something that counts as the real story.

02 Installation and the private threshold

The local application serves its interface and API together. The production entry point requires an owner password, same-origin requests and authenticated sessions. On first run, use the setup code printed by the server and choose the owner password. This is a private, single-owner installation, not a multi-user account service. Keep the server local unless you deliberately configure secure network access using the Operations and Security handbooks.

The 5.0 programme is a new-product release. Do not point development builds at an older installation's database. Use a separate checkout and fresh data. Opening older databases and story saves is not a 5.0 compatibility commitment. During development, the package/schema cutover is a later release-hardening batch.

After unlocking, the story shelf is the starting point. Lock closes the private interface, clears its private working state and revokes that browser session. Remembered login does not imply that encrypted provider credentials remain unlocked after the server restarts.

03 Start with a situation

Choose **Start a story**. Supply a title and a situation worth exploring. For example: two old friends meet again, and one has something to confess. A clear situation gives the narrator something to develop without requiring a world bible.

Choose character drama, mystery, exploration or cozy discovery. Genre guides the narration; it is not a promise of a specific ruleset or dice system.

Two authored openings are available. **The Drowned Bell** begins a harbour mystery with a small cast and fixed hidden truths; **The Garden After Rain** offers quiet cooperation with no hidden catastrophe. Choose the opening, then Begin this story. Its cast, opening and facts are included without a provider call. Characters you add are additional people. **Use my own situation** clears the preset.

Open **Cast and story preferences** when you want more control. You can add a few characters, describe who they are and what they want, choose pacing, select gentle or dramatic consequences, and state tone or content boundaries. None of the characters must represent you. Initial casts support at most 24 members. A current local character template can be copied into the starting cast; this does not link the story to future template edits.

Starting is a local, free operation. It does not call a provider, paint a cover or prepare speculative prose. Curated scenarios include an opening to read. For your own situation, Continue invites the first generated passage explicitly. There is no manual prose editor or hand-written opening field.

04 Follow, steer, or ask

Continue invites the narrator to develop the cast and situation. You can read several moments without typing a direction. You are not failing to participate by leaning back and enjoying what happens.

The direction box lets you intervene as a reader-director: “Stay with their reunion,” “Show the sister's perspective,” or “Let the awkwardness breathe.” Choose **Steer the story**, then **Send direction**. Ctrl/Command + Enter sends the same action while the direction box has focus.

The default is **This moment only**: your direction shapes this response, not every later scene. Choose **Keep this focus** only for an ongoing instruction. It becomes visible above the direction box after a successful response. **Clear ongoing focus** releases it locally, without an AI request. A one-moment detour does not erase an existing focus. Failed requests keep both your text and scope.

Possible directions (optional) offers a few intentions from reader-visible context. Choosing one fills the box for review; edit or send it when ready. Nothing has happened merely because you selected it. Existing drafts are not overwritten, and Continue never requires an invitation.

Choose **Ask outside the story** for clarification. The answer is displayed as out-of-story discussion, not as an event that happened. It must not change world state or advance fictional time. Asking still uses the text provider and can cost money. It is not a back door to undiscovered secrets.

Every paid action immediately shows busy feedback and disables duplicate actions. A successful response saves readable prose and its validated state changes together. There is no automatic paid successor or background NPC simulation.

05 Choose your storyteller

Open **Settings** to inspect the selected storyteller and provider. The logical backend role is named Scribe; in this interface it is your storyteller. Choose a text provider and model identifier, or browse that provider's model catalogue. Save the assignment explicitly. An unavailable model is not silently replaced.

The built-in OpenRouter profile uses a read-only environment credential. To enter a key in the interface, add a separate OpenAI-compatible provider profile, choose it, and save its credential. The endpoint must be HTTPS or supported loopback HTTP. Keep the key in server-session memory or encrypted in the local vault. Encrypted storage requires the owner password. Keys never enter stories, browser storage, ordinary API responses or portable story material.

Model browsing is not a generated story operation, but it contacts the provider's catalogue. Initial story creation and local corrections do not need model browsing.

The first paid review explains the operation and what is sent. It names the provider and model and includes a rough cost estimate, not a spending cap. Existing device consent is remembered; later deliberate paid actions may run without a new modal. Relevant hidden world truth may be supplied to the narrator even though it is not shown in the reader's recap. Do not enter material you are unwilling to send to your chosen provider. If the reviewed provider/model changes before a new request begins, refresh and review the new configuration.

06 Model consistency and fair resistance

Prose fluency, price, speed, continuity and resistance are different model qualities. Some models become too accommodating when challenged repeatedly. Do not assume a newer, larger or more expensive storyteller is a better referee. No models have yet been certified by an InkMorrow live comparison; recommendations must name the tested model version, settings and date rather than a timeless winner.

Choose **Story-shaping** or **Living-world** when beginning, or change **Play style** in Story preferences. The first honours desired developments within continuity; the second allows credible resistance based on motives, knowledge, relationships and circumstances. Neither requires you to become a character. The selected style is visible in the reader. Changes apply to future play on this path; they do not reverse recorded outcomes. Rewind restores the style recorded at that moment.

A royal guard should not grant entry simply because a request is repeated, but should reconsider genuinely sufficient authority. Structured challenge decisions are application-owned, and repeating an unchanged decision makes no new provider request. This protection applies to explicit structured challenges, not a promise that every free-form character conversation is mechanically reliable. Contradictory generated sentences remain possible even when state cannot be changed that way.

For stories with structured challenges, **Cast & story** → **Approaches to this situation** offers explicit approaches and shows recorded outcomes. The game first checks locally whether an existing ruling still applies. Unchanged rulings need no paid review or provider purchase; new attempts use the ordinary paid boundary. **Read the decision moment** opens its actual record. Controls concerning a person you inhabit do not supply that person's decisions for you.

07 Let characters address the reader

Living-world has a separate **Characters may break the fourth wall** setting. Choose it when starting a story or in **Cast & story** → **Story preferences**. It defaults to **Never**. Changing it is local and makes no provider request.

- **Never:** characters remain within the fiction rather than knowingly speaking to you as its reader. Ordinary dialogue between characters is still welcome.
- **Rarely:** the storyteller may include an occasional fitting address. The application permits at most one structured address in six narrated passages: five ordinary passages must intervene before another. It need not use every opportunity. Clarifications, failed attempts and free repeated rulings do not advance that cooldown.
- **Freely:** characters may address you whenever it fits. This is permission, not a demand for jokes or an aside after every paragraph.

An address appears with the character's name and **to you** in the saved passage. For example, Jo might look beyond the garden and ask the reader whether the kettle was optimistic. You can respond through Steer without becoming a cast member. **Ask outside the story** remains a separate narrator clarification, not a character's fourth-wall address. The setting is inactive in Story-shaping; its choice is retained if you switch back to Living-world.

Fourth-wall permission does not relax resistance, grant a challenge, reveal a hidden solution, or let the narrator speak for a character you inhabit. Asides cannot supply evidence for a world-state effect. No additional model call is needed for the address. Its text travels with the passage in books and saves; rewind and save-copy restore the setting and cooldown on the selected path.

These checks constrain structured addresses. A model can still disobey instructions in ordinary prose; **Never** is not a proof of semantic model compliance. If it repeatedly breaks immersion, switch to Never, review the storyteller choice and use an alternative path as appropriate. No automatic paid repair is purchased.

08 Optional character control

Open **Cast & story** and select **Inhabit** beside a cast member. Read the handoff and choose **Take this role**. The reader now names the controlled character, and the input selector adds acting and speaking as that character.

Act describes an intention, not a guaranteed outcome. Say supplies your character's speech. The narrator portrays the surroundings and other people; it must not invent the controlled character's decisions, speech, thoughts or commitments. Continue may develop the surrounding situation but should stop at a decision that belongs to you. Structural state checks reinforce these boundaries, but generated sentences can still be wrong: retain your editorial judgment.

Return to reader-director releases the role explicitly. The narrator again runs the cast. Your existing story and history are not replaced or converted.

09 What matters now

A small scene director makes recorded history consequential. A live commitment can create a later opportunity or acknowledgement; a goal can make a new approach relevant. Cooldowns discourage immediate repetition. Genre and pacing also leave space for discovery, relationships, ordinary activity and aftermath. A suggested scene is a plan, not a fact or a guaranteed outcome. Only the resulting validated passage can record an event, fulfil a promise or reveal hidden truth.

The **What matters now** panel shows reader-visible durable facts, commitments, relationships, goals and resources. Hidden truths are not listed. Characters' knowledge is tracked separately from the truth of a fact.

A generated passage may expose **What changed**. This is an optional explanation of recorded effects, not a scorecard. Small expressive choices do not need a permanent statistic. A major commitment should be recorded and remain available to future narration.

The current working set holds up to 128 facts, with up to twelve effects in one response. Older facts remain in permanent path history and relevant ones can be recalled automatically. You do not need to prune memory to keep playing. The narrator receives bounded recent text and relevant facts rather than the entire accumulated story on every call.

10 Correct a mistake

Recall older facts searches this path's public memory, including records no longer in the current working set. Enter distinctive words and choose **Search memory**. Results are bounded to 32; refine the words rather than loading the entire story. Secret and retired records and other paths are excluded. You can read a record's evidence, correct it, or explicitly retire it here without AI.

Read recorded evidence opens the actual source moment. **What changed** links to the earlier record when a fact changed; an initial fact has no invented scene citation. Local correction records explain that earlier prose was not rewritten, and never display private correction reasons.

Choose **Correct a story fact**. Select an existing reader-visible fact or add a missing one, state what is true, and give a reason. Save the correction.

Corrections affect future narration on this path. They do not silently rewrite earlier prose, and they have no in-world penalty. The reason is retained privately in the correction record, not displayed as reader prose. A correction is different from deciding that you would rather have made another choice.

State validation checks structure and evidence, not every possible semantic contradiction. A fluent response can still be mistaken. If something important is wrong, correct it explicitly rather than hoping repetition will repair it.

Retire a fact explicitly stops using an entry for future narration on this path, with a reason. Earlier prose and earlier path snapshots retain it. This is a correction tool, not required memory maintenance: automatic working-set compaction already preserves older facts for retrieval. Do not retire commitments you still want to matter.

11 Cast and story preferences

Add to the cast introduces another person locally. Reader-visible description is separate from their private motive. Generated scenes can also introduce new named people, up to the 24-person cast bound. Neither route hands you a character.

Story preferences changes play style, pacing, consequence tone, content boundaries and narration voice on this path. The attention field shows a deliberately retained focus; clear it to release that focus. Preferences are restored with a rewind. Pacing does not change model randomness, and dramatic consequences do not imply constant danger. Voice guides style without overriding character control or boundaries.

12 Rewind and explore alternatives

Rewind a choice creates a new path from an earlier moment while preserving the original. Choose the moment after which the new path should continue and name it. Choose the beginning to return to before the opening.

Explore an alternative uses the same complete-state branching mechanism, usually beginning at the current moment. It is for keeping multiple possibilities, not pretending earlier text is erased. At most 40 paths are supported per story.

The path selector returns to any saved path. Its facts, resources, commitments, knowledge and control state come with it. A promise made only on one path must not appear on another. Use **Read earlier moments** if the desired fork point is older than the currently loaded history window.

These operations are local and free. They are refused while a paid response is pending, or when another tab has changed the story since the displayed revision. Refresh rather than repeatedly pressing the same action.

13 End an episode and return later

An episode is a useful stopping point, not an obligation to keep generating. Choose **End this episode**, optionally supply a short recap, and confirm. The reader offers a resting surface instead of another generation button.

Your story is saved. The world does not move forward while you are away, and characters do not punish absence from the app. When you want to continue, choose **Begin another episode** and name it. Cast, history and commitments remain.

Ending remains explicitly reader-controlled. The scene director can invite a resting point after a resolved thread but cannot end the episode for you.

14 Failures, costs and recovery

If a reply fails, your direction remains in the input box. Invalid provider output can still incur a charge. The interface reports the failure and makes a free read to reconcile the story; it never automatically buys a replacement response.

The story header distinguishes known provider spend from attempts whose actual cost is unknown. Unknown cost is not zero. Returning to a completed request with the same operation key does not buy another completion; failed requests require a new deliberate action.

If another tab or action changed the story, refresh before continuing. A late reply cannot paint a different story you have opened. After a server restart, abandoned requests are marked interrupted rather than reported successful. Dispatched work whose response was lost remains an unknown-cost attempt, not a free one. Story purchases allow one transport attempt: even an uncertain network failure cannot silently trigger another request.

Use Download a playable save for a complete game, not older manuscript export endpoints. Also keep operator-level cold backups of this isolated installation. Never overwrite older user data.

15 Illustrate a moment

In Cast & story, choose Illustrate a moment. The dialog opens immediately. Select a loaded story passage and supply an image description. Read earlier moments first to illustrate an older passage. Images appear **above** their associated prose.

Upload image accepts a local raster file up to 20 MB and makes no provider request. The server removes metadata/animation, normalizes orientation and stores a bounded WebP. Unsupported or unsafe files are refused without changing the story.

Paint with AI uses the separate Illustrator provider/model in Settings. The selected passage and art direction are sent; hidden facts, motives, other passages and uploaded image references are not. It buys one image attempt, with no automatic retry. Cancellation and failure retain your direction. Charges may still occur on failure. Check the result and use Save description only to correct its accessible description without buying another image.

Replacing or removing an image changes only the current path. Earlier snapshots retain the old illustration. Rewind can restore it. There is a 200-illustrated-moment limit per path and a 400-image limit per story including historical assets.

16 Export a reading path or keep a playable save

Choose Export this reading path for a book: EPUB, PDF, HTML, DOCX, ODT, RTF, Markdown, plain text or JSON. Supply an optional author credit and language tag. Only current-path prose and placed images are included—not private facts, motives, questions, directions or other paths. No AI request is made. EPUB images each have a separate page immediately before their prose; text remains resizable. Text-only formats describe illustrations instead of embedding pixels. Missing media makes export fail visibly rather than silently producing a broken book.

Choose Download a playable save to preserve **all** paths and continue elsewhere. The `.inkmorrow5` file includes cast, hidden truth, commitments, knowledge, control, episodes, director history, illustrations and aggregate known/unknown spend. It excludes credentials, provider configuration, payment consent and pending requests. It is unencrypted: keep it private, and use a book to share with ordinary readers.

On Your stories, choose Import a playable save. Select the file, Check this save, review its story/path/moment/image counts, then Import as a new story. The original is never overwritten. No provider call starts. Configure credentials separately on the destination. Older `.inkmorrow` archives and databases are not accepted. Portable saves support up to 10,000 moments, 40 paths, 64 MB compressed and 128 MB expanded, with conservative preflight for unusually large stories. Keep a cold operator backup as well. A downloaded book cannot restore the playable world.

17 Example journeys

Revisit without spending

Return to a saved story, reread earlier scenes, review discoveries and commitments, and compare existing paths. None of these actions calls a provider. You can also read a curated opening before configuring a storyteller. New generated scenes require AI: InkMorrow does not offer a separate non-AI game or manual writing mode.

Follow a developing relationship

Choose a configured storyteller, start a character drama and supply a small cast. Continue through the reunion, then steer toward the part that interests you. Leave character control unused. Consult What changed only when useful, correct an important mistake and stop at an episode ending. Paid text calls send bounded story context; local state actions are free. Return to the same path tomorrow.

Step into one conversation

Begin as reader-director. At a conversation you care about, inhabit one cast member explicitly, supply their words, and let the narrator portray the response. Release the role when you want to lean back again. Fork before a commitment if you want to explore an alternative without losing the original. Skip unrelated media and authoring tools. You remain in one persistent, readable story.

Use all current reader features

Configure a provider and optional encrypted credential, supply cast and boundaries, alternate following with steering, ask an out-of-story question, briefly inhabit a character, inspect a change, correct a fact, compare paths, and end an episode. Try an authored opening, make a commitment through play, change voice and pacing, and notice how later narration can respond to that commitment. Illustrate a passage with an uploaded image or one explicit Illustrator request. Correct its description locally, export the selected reading path as EPUB, and download a private playable save. Import that save as a new story to verify that the alternate paths and image are present. Text/image provider actions are paid; upload, local changes, export and save/import are not.